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GST 102: Use of English II - Essays, Letters and Advanced Comprehension

Write the essays, letters and reports that university assessment actually rewards

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

GST 102 moves from sentence rules to whole pieces of writing. This pack gives you reusable structures for argumentative and expository essays, formal letters, reports and minutes, plus a marking-style checklist so you can grade your own drafts before your lecturer does.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Plan an argumentative or expository essay in five minutes using a clear thesis and paragraph outline.
- Write a formal letter, application letter and simple report with correct layout and register.
- Use cohesive devices without overusing 'moreover' and 'furthermore'.
- Edit your own draft for structure, grammar, punctuation and word choice.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The five-minute essay plan

Most weak essays fail at the planning stage. Five minutes of planning saves twenty minutes of confused writing.

1. Underline the instruction words: discuss, argue, compare, describe, evaluate. Each demands a different structure.
2. Write a one-sentence thesis: the exact position your essay will defend.
3. List three body points. Each must be different, relevant and supportable.
4. For each body point, note one example or piece of evidence.

5. Decide your conclusion in one sentence before you start writing.

> **The thesis test**
> If your thesis could be agreed with by everyone, it is too vague. 'Technology is useful' is not a thesis. 'Smartphones help freshers study only when notifications are controlled' is.

Paragraph architecture

A body paragraph should do one job: prove one point. The most reliable pattern is claim, explanation, evidence, link.

- Claim: a topic sentence that states the point directly.
- Explanation: why the claim is true in your context.
- Evidence: an example, statistic, experience or reference.
- Link: connect back to the thesis or forward to the next point.
- Keep paragraphs between four and eight sentences. Very long paragraphs hide your argument.

Argumentative versus expository essays

Both need structure, but they answer different questions.

- Argumentative: take a side, acknowledge the strongest opposing view, then rebut it. Do not sit on the fence unless the question asks you to.
- Expository: explain a process, concept or phenomenon clearly. Your job is clarity, not persuasion.
- Narrative: tell a story with a point. Avoid ending with 'and that was how I learnt a lesson' unless the lesson is specific.
- Compare and contrast: organise by criteria (cost, speed, reliability) rather than describing one item fully and then the other.

> **Counter-argument formula**
> Some students argue that X because Y. That view has merit, but it overlooks Z. When Z is considered, X becomes less convincing than it first appears.

Formal letters without embarrassment

Formal letters are marked on layout, tone and completeness as much as on grammar.

- Two addresses: your address, then the recipient's address, then the date.
- Salutation: 'Dear Sir/Madam' when the name is unknown; 'Dear Mr Okafor' when known.
- Subject line: short and specific, for example 'Application for the Position of Library Assistant'.
- Opening: state your purpose in the first two sentences. Do not begin with 'I am writing this letter to tell you that'.
- Body: one paragraph per issue. Be direct and courteous.
- Closing: 'Yours faithfully' after 'Dear Sir/Madam'; 'Yours sincerely' after a named recipient.